

Why is AI the only use of the internet that people get mad about when it comes to destroying our environment?

Posted by u/kiwipangolin • 0 points • 10 comments

I'll start by saying I do not support the use of AI at all. I am an artist and do not enjoy the way that ai has grown and become so dependent on by so many people. I also find that many times it gives the wrong information anyway when people ask it questions so I find it to be a waste of time and a bad thing for people to trust and use.

I just noticed that a lot of people say that AI destroys the environment; which it does, but doesn't every use of the internet destroy the environment? Things like online servers that take hefty computers and a lot of power to run, stuff like that, etc...

They say to use google to search stuff because AI destroys the environment, but doesn't google also do the same? are AI sites really the only sites that destroy the environment? Am I just not understanding the issue correctly?

I casually mentioned to someone how AI being used so stupidly, such as to mess with it or ask it dumb stuff just to see its reply, is ruining the environment and I got the response back that everything online is using trees and electricity to run it so "what's the issue". It made me think on what really is the true difference between chatgpt (and whatever other sites there are out there) and google when it comes to how much power they're wasting.

Comments

u/illogictc • 3 points • 2025-09-07 20:48 UTC

I can't recall tech companies making deals to restart whole-ass nuclear plants to power web searches, but that kind of deal HAS been struck to power AI. How much power a ChatGPT prompt requires varies wildly on the input and the output, but it can be pretty power-hungry.

u/kiwipangolin • 1 points • 2025-09-07 20:50 UTC

Oh wow. Yea I assumed that it would've been that it takes a lot more power because of how "accessible" and popular it is right now, but I wanted to know if there was other reasons that I may not have been aware of. I was not aware of how they restart entire nuclear plants to power these sites

u/illogictc • 2 points • 2025-09-07 21:04 UTC

<https://www.nbcnews.com/now/video/three-mile-island-nuclear-plant-fast-tracked-to-reopen-for-ai-energy-demand-242399301556>

Yep. And I mean hey at least it's a nuclear plant. Like if AI companies could focus on getting (or even funding) cleaner greener energy to do what they do, that'd be cool. But of course they're also working on making their models more efficient etc as well because at the end of the day needing less power and compute time for the same results is money saved on their end, but I personally have zero clue just how far they could push with that.

u/cpuguy83 • 2 points • 2025-09-07 21:03 UTC

It consumes a lot of power because it consumes a lot of power.
Even running AI on your local machine just for you consumes a ton of power (as much as the GPU can push).

u/GameboyPATH • 6 points • 2025-09-07 20:46 UTC

1. Gen AI uses disproportionately more energy than most other internet-related functions. Servers suck down a lot of energy, sure, but they manage traffics across many, many, many users, and hold a lot of valuable information that's necessary for the infrastructure of most web-based services and platforms. When we look at their usefulness and their per-person energy usage, servers seem a lot more justified than "quickly make me a crappy piece of art" Gen AI models.

2. Gen AI is an emerging new technology that a not-insignificant number of people don't consider necessary or relevant. So people are definitely going to favor what's been well-established, and seems more integral to the core features of what we use computers and internet for, than this new toy that ****might**** be useful.

u/Realistic-Cow-7839 • 5 points • 2025-09-07 20:45 UTC

I believe typing and submitting a quick question to an AI system consumes much more energy than typing and sending a quick email.

u/kiwipangolin • 1 points • 2025-09-07 20:48 UTC

I was just confused on why it was more harmful than a google search. Is it because of the likelihood of it getting the answer wrong and spreading misinformation?

u/Realistic-Cow-7839 • 3 points • 2025-09-07 21:06 UTC

I misread your question, but my answer is still a partial answer to it. Even if the AI takes exactly the same amount of energy to find websites as an old-school search, the AI spends much more energy to the cost by reading the websites and presenting a summary in natural language.

u/cpuguy83 • 4 points • 2025-09-07 21:01 UTC

A Google search comparatively uses ***far*** less resources.

The thing to understand is, AI is putting tremendous strain on power infrastructure, and there literally is not enough of it to build out what is needed to continue to grow AI.

It is ***power hungry***.

Energy is not even the only market that I is straining.

u/that0neBl1p • 2 points • 2025-09-07 20:58 UTC

misinformation + creative/copyright theft + data centers consuming *far* more energy and resources than general servers

u/kiwipangolin • 1 points • 2025-09-07 21:00 UTC

Very true. The art / copyright theft is a big reason why I like to avoid AI use at all costs

u/Ganceany • 1 points • 2025-09-07 20:45 UTC

Its a matter of popularity, in the next few years something else will appear and that will be the environmentally dangerous thing.

u/Astramancer_ • 6 points • 2025-09-07 20:44 UTC

It's not *just* that it destroys the environment by using excessive amounts of power and fresh water. It's that it does so for dubious benefit.

Imagine there's two cars. There's a standard gasoline engine car. Not great, uses fossil fuels to get you from point A to point B with a modest efficiency of 25 miles per gallon.

Then there's the BurnMaster5000 that uses 5 pounds of bunker fuel to to drive one mile, is 2 and half lanes wide, and is actively trying to run people off the road but sometimes maps your route for you but usually makes wrong turns and entirely different destinations than you wanted to reach so you have to keep trying until you eventually get to where you want to go.

Do you think people would get mad at the BurnMaster5000 for destroying the environment even through regular cars exist?